

MENTOR TEXT | NONFICTION NARRATIVE

This selection is an example of a **nonfiction narrative**, a type of writing in which an author tells a true story. This is the type of writing you will develop in the Performance-Based Assessment at the end of the unit.

READ IT As you read, look at the way the author describes events and experiences. Mark the text to help you answer this question: What descriptive details make this narrative realistic and memorable?

Wagon Train at Dusk



AUDIO



ANNOTATE

- 1 Sometimes you just have to laugh," I tell my daughter, who is having an especially bad day. She's lost her favorite bracelet, she turned in the wrong homework assignment, and she just found out she would be playing Marshmallow #2 in the class play.
- 2 "Oh, you wouldn't understand," Sarah says, sulkily.
- 3 I ask her if I've ever told her the story of the diorama.
- 4 "Yes, Dad. More than once," she says.
- 5 That doesn't stop me. "When I was in the sixth grade," I say in my storyteller's voice, "we had to make shoebox dioramas of a scene from American history. I decided to do a wagon train traveling across the Great Plains in the mid-1800s."
- 6 Sarah pretends she isn't rolling her eyes, but I keep going. "I wanted it to be great. A diorama to end all dioramas! I wanted to be famous. I wanted to be on the local news. But what I really wanted was to show up Jorge Nuñez," I say.
- 7 "Jorge and I had been in the same class since fourth grade. We were pretty evenly matched when it came to test scores and homework, but for hands-on projects, there was no one like Jorge. He always came up with these unique creations, beautifully conceived and executed. Jorge's mom and dad were architects, so maybe he had a leg up, but who knows."
- 8 Sarah shrugs in sympathy—which I take as permission to continue. "As soon as I heard Jorge announce that he was making a shoebox diorama of a log cabin, I decided to go one better. I'd create a fleet of Conestoga wagons in a circle formation around a campfire at dusk, with miniature people and horses and dogs made of pipe cleaners, and children running around playing

hoops. It would be a masterpiece. And that's just how it turned out: a masterpiece! I carried it upstairs to my room and that night I went to sleep with a smile on my face, imagining Jorge's reaction."

9 "Then," I go on, "in the middle of the night I was jolted awake by a ripping sound. My heart stopped. I felt sick. *I know that sound*, I thought. There was no mistaking what it was—Lucy was demolishing my masterpiece! You couldn't even tell what it was supposed to be! I lay there in a stupor of self-pity and the sense that nothing in the world would ever be right again. *The dog ate my diorama*, I thought, and I pictured myself saying this in class. I pictured the hoots and guffaws and hollers. I pictured my teacher's puzzled expression as she tried to work out if I was being serious." I make the expression myself, and Sarah smiles.

10 "Then I said it out loud: *The dog ate my diorama*. It was funny, actually. The more I said it, the funnier it got. I started laughing. I laughed until my sides hurt. I couldn't stop laughing."

11 "And then?" Sarah says, knowing what comes next.

12 "Well," I say, "I picked up all the pieces and put them in the box and took the whole thing to school. I called it 'Wagon Train After a Tornado.' The teacher loved it. Everyone enjoyed my story. I think Jorge was actually jealous."

13 Sarah gives a reluctant smile, like she's supposed to. "So," she says, remembering that there's a lesson in there somewhere, "you learned to laugh at bad things. Right?"

14 I shake my head. "Nope," I tell her. "I learned that some things aren't so bad." 🐼

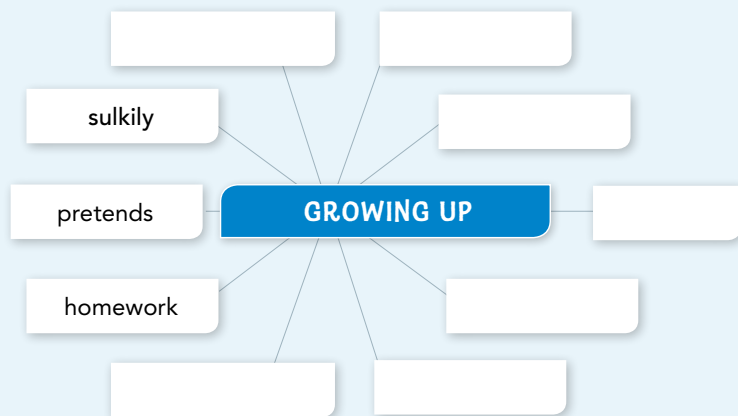


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WORD NETWORK FOR GROWING UP

Vocabulary A Word Network is a collection of words related to a topic.

As you read the selections in this unit, identify interesting words related to growing up, and add them to your Word Network. For example, you might begin by adding basic words from the Mentor Text, such as *pretends*, as well as more complex terms, such as *sulkily* and *homework*. Continue to add words as you complete this unit.



Refer to the **Word Network Model** in the **Tool Kit** at the back of this book.